

INTL 511- INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS THEORY

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Midterm Exams

Section 1: Short Answer Questions (20%)

- Purpose: To assess specific knowledge of key arguments and concepts from readings.

1. Realism in Donnelly: "According to Jack Donnelly's discussion of Realism, how does Kenneth Waltz's structural realism differ from classical realism?"

Realism is one of the first and oldest theories of international relations that argues that states are not only rational actors in the global system, but are equally the principle and primary actors in both domestic and international affairs. The concept of the worldview can be traced back to the works of thinkers like Thomas Hobbes, Hans Machiavelli, and Thucydides whose contributions to the discipline have shaped the idea of realism in International Relations. These realist thinkers are of the view that power, self-interest, fear, and honor are the driving forces of state behavior in an anarchic global system that lacks central authority. The theory has two important variants: Neorealism also referred to as structural realism and classical realism.

In Burchill et. al, Jack Donnelly dates the concept of classical realism back to a period in 1939 connecting it to Edward Hallett Carr's *The 20 Years Crisis* (1939). Classical realists argue that because the desire for power is rooted in the flawed nature of humanity, states are continuously engaged in a struggle to increase their capacities. For classical realists, international politics can be characterized as evil associating states behavior as having rational foundations. In 1960, the concept came under increasing scrutiny by scholars who disagree with Morgenthau and other Classical realists revealing substantive inconsistencies and contradictions. For Waltz, hierarchy

and anarchy are the main political ordering principles. His views focus on the anarchic structure of the international system, the balance of power, and how weaker states “Bandwagon” on powerful states for survival. An example of this is the U.S- Soviet alignment against Nazi Germany in World War II. However, in the absence of a strong government, when a weaker state forms an alliance with a stronger power it may likely lose its sovereignty like the case of Finland USSR alliance.

The difference between classical realist and structural realism lies in their differing opinions on the source and content of states’ preferences. Unlike classical realists, neorealist dismiss the relevance of the internal makeup of states. For example, Morgenthau holds a firm belief that leaders of states’ are motivated by their desire for power. Waltz emphasizes the structure of the international system, dismissing a leader’s motivation and state characteristics as factors for international outcomes. In short, classical realists associate the causes of conflict to the flawed nature of individuals in decision making positions, whereas Waltz holds the belief that the anarchic nature of the international system forces states to pursue their interest in any given opportunity.

2. Liberal Internationalism: "What are the core tenets of Liberal Internationalism post-Cold War, as outlined by [Burchill](#)?"

Liberal internationalism is one of the theories of international relations that emerged in the enlightenment period and reached its height as a systematic statement of international reform with Woodrow Wilson’s fourteen points, intended to form the basis of the post WWI peace. Liberals had the assumption that the outbreak of WWI had vindicated their critique of the system of international relations, seeking to create a liberal peace through open diplomacy, the right to self-determination and self-defense, free trade and the creation of an international security organization

to promote peace and security. One of the first organizations that was birthed through this idea was the League of Nations which was later replaced by the United Nations after World War I.

The core tenets of Liberal Internationalism post-Cold War, as outlined in Burchill et. al., includes promotion of bilateral and multilateral relations and increased interdependency between states through the different international organizations such as the World Bank, World Trade organization, and the International Monetary Fund, etc. institutions created to uphold peace, unity and global cooperation. They also advocate for the consolidation of democratic liberal values such as protection of human rights, international law and domestic laws both at the local and global levels of society. This idea is anchored in the works of Immanuel Kant who used the concept of “democratic peace theory” to build on his idea of “perpetual peace” which suggests that lasting peace is achievable through promotion of democratic principles. Michael Doyle, is also another key proponent of the theory who emphasized the importance of achieving global peace through the promotion of both international and constitutional laws of states. He argued that countries with common values and beliefs have peaceful diplomatic relations and are less likely to go to war with each other than undemocratic states.

Additionally, liberal internationalism post-cold war period, emphasized the importance of global governance in a system of anarchy through the United Nations to not only address issues of security threat and international cooperation but to collectively address global problems that needs global solutions like climate change etc.

After the collapse of the Soviet Union, scholars like Francis Fukuyama, *The End of History*, (1989) became optimistic about the idea of liberalism. However, the failure of liberal approaches in Bosnia, Rwanda and Somalia proved that liberal internationalism has limitations, including

inconsistent foreign engagements and contradictions. Despite these, the principles of the theory continues to shape global governance strengthening arguments of scholars like Woodrow Wilson, Robert Keohane, and Joseph Nye who posit that cooperation is possible even in anarchy.

3. Critical Theory by Linklater: "What role does the 'politics of knowledge' play in shaping IR according to Linklater?"

Unlike the mainstream theories, critical theory is one of the most controversial theories of international relations believe to originate from the Frankfurt School in the twentieth century who assumes that freedom and equality are the highest moral ends but are not valued everywhere and are understood differently. The theory, similar to constructivism challenges the traditional theories of international relations for neglecting the real problems of society. Thinkers like Max Horkheimer, Theodor Adorno, Walter Benjamin, Herbert Marcuse, Jurgen Habermas, and Andrew Linklater in their writings reveal the inequalities created by the structure of the international system by accessing the societal norms and practices. They challenge the existing structure and inequalities in the world, aiming for a better world where social change is prioritized. Linklater's politics of knowledge reveals the biases and exclusions of the traditional theories by focusing on knowledge production and how that sustains power structures.

Linklater criticizes the positivist approach to studying international relations which he argues neglects the important social, political and historical state in which knowledge is produced. Politics of knowledge also emphasized the use of normative approaches in the study of international relations and the involvement of marginalized groups in world affairs to promote diversity, (Linklatere, 1998). Unlike the mainstream theories of IR that mainly focuses on power dynamics, politics of knowledge by Linklater stressed the importance of dialogue among global actors as emphasized by Habermas who redefined the role of critical theory by going beyond Marx's

economic views of capitalism to include “communicative actions” which include broader cultural, and social dimensions. He argues that effective dialogue and communication where there is mutual understanding and where people's views are recognized and respected are the key drivers of social change not material wealth or Marx’s model of emancipation. These ideas have immensely contributed to shaping the field as it does not only offer an alternative approach to the study of International relations, but also aims to emancipate people who are oppressed by the existing system. It also address issues such as ethics and injustice in the global system and completes our understanding of the complexities of international relations.

4. Constructivism in Reus-Smit: "According to Reus-Smit, how does anarchy differ based on social interactions and shared norms? Provide a quote from the assigned readings to support your answer."

The theory of constructivism emerged in the post-Cold War period, sharing similar concerns to those expressed by critical theorist but differing ontologically with rationalist thinkers. For constructivists, the main concepts of International Relations are made through social interaction. They posit that social norms, values, and beliefs shape society not material wealth or international institutions as realist and liberals claim. They analyze social practices by studying the nature of reality (ontology) and the nature of knowledge (epistemology). Unlike rationalists, constructivists see the relationship between individuals and structures as reciprocally constitutive. Rationalist and constructivists differ in their concepts of the dominant logic governing individual's actions. Rationalists see states as rational actors whose actions are driven by their state interest, not norms and values as constructivists claim.

Reus-Smit holds the view that states' interaction through shared beliefs, norms and identities shape the international system which is subject to change depending on the relationship that these states share. Additionally, constructivists argue that material structures acquire social significance only via the intersubjectively shared meaning structures through which they are mediated. They believe that material things like nuclear weapons only gain meaning not from their physical existence, but through shared social beliefs (Wendt, 1992). The international system is therefore seen by constructivists as being a constitutive rather than merely a strategic domain (Reus-Smit 1996)

Reus-Smit views anarchy as an important feature of the global system which according to realist propels states to pursue their national interest in any given situation or opportunity. The approach is state-centric and has ethical implications for many countries. The period after the Cold War exposed the international system to new threats and challenges from both state and non-state actors particularly those engaged in global governance affairs due to its changing political, social and economic dynamics, strengthening the arguments among constructivist that indeed the international system is not governed by material wealth alone. Reus-Smit further emphasized this by arguing that "Anarchy does not exist independently of the social structures that states create. Rather, anarchy is constituted by the shared understandings that states create through their interactions. In this sense, anarchy is a social condition, one in which the meaning of security, war, and cooperation is fundamentally shaped by social relations and collective understandings." (Reus-Smit, 1999, p. 18)

Section 2: Analytical Essays (50%)

1. Prompt 1: "Compare how Marxism and Critical Theory approach global capitalism. Include arguments from [Griffiths](#), and discuss the influence of global capitalism."

Marxism as proposed by Karl Marx is a worldview that focuses on exposing the crisis of capitalism, class differences between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat and the idea of historical materialism which explores how humans through socially organized productive activity reproduced the condition of their existence. (Griffiths, 2007). Karl Marx's view of the world is that humans shape their world and social activities through social structures but are at risk of losing control of this system in a biased capitalist economy that marginalized the poor and less privilege, (Marx & Engels, 1848). Marxists argue that capitalism is an economic system designed to not only allow the wealthy class of society to manage the means of production, distribution and exchange, but to also control and oppress the vulnerable working class of society.

Critical theory amongst other issues also addresses the negative impact of capitalism on the vulnerable groups of society and disparities its causing particularly in countries in the global south that continue to face huge social and economic inequality. Both theories offer different but similar views on the concept of global capitalism for instance, prominent Marxist scholars like Karl Marx, Friedrich Engels, and Lenin argued that capitalism oppresses and exploits the working class of society drawing on the difference between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat. Similarly, Herbert Marcuse in his 1964 "One-Dimensional Man" saw the modern industrial society as a form of social control, arguing that the Western system that is believed to be democratic is in fact totalitarian. Marcuse critiques how capitalism created a "One Dimensional Man" system that empowers the

powerful and the wealthy at the expense of the poor. Habermas (1990), also argued that capitalism has led to “colonization of the life world”, but hoped for revolutionary change through human rights movements, gender equality campaigns, and environmental concerns. Marx’s influence on the Frankfurt School is philosophical, however, Horkheimer argued that soviet Marxism encourages authoritarianism and oppression rather than freedom.

Additionally, Vladimir Lenin in one of his famous works “Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism (1917)” also argued that modern capitalism is one of the contributing factors to imperialism especially in developing countries. Industrialized powers in their quest to expand their economies extended their influence to developing countries in the global south where they have access to natural resources, cheap labor and in turn use their markets for their processed finished goods (Lenin, 1917). In the capitalist view, this increase economic growth in these countries through foreign direct investment, however, it also increase exploitation and underdevelopment, widening the income inequality gap between countries in the core, the semi periphery and the periphery.

“Capitalism as Marx represents it, is not a seamless web of oppression, but rather a contradicting life of dual freedom,” (Griffiths, 2007). On the one hand, workers under a capitalist economic system are free from ownership of the means of production and on the other hand, because they have no access to the means of production, they sell their labor as a means of survival which puts them at risk of being exploited. Marxists have also argued that capitalism undermines the social interaction between people thus it overlooks social aspects of society and emphasizes economic activities. They hold that a revolutionary movement will rise to challenge the dominant concept of capitalism, believing in the project of emancipation to free mankind from the oppression created by a flawed system.

In contrary, Critical theorists emphasized cultural and ideological dominations. Critical theorist are more concerned with raising a certain degree of critical consciousness and cultural reform. In critical theory, emancipation goes beyond the economic aspects of life to include social, cultural, ideological, and technological freedoms.

The influence of global capitalism going by views of both Marxist and Critical thinkers are enormous. Apart from creating economic inequality, global capitalism outshines the traditional cultural believes of local indigenous people of society under the claim of modernization which Marxist believe is a byproduct of capitalism. For Critical thinkers, these when supported by the media and cultural industries undermine cultures and traditions of people. To critical theorists, capitalism does not only control economic systems, it also creates a homogenized culture.

Despite spreading western ideology which influences global norms and values, increased dependency, economic inequality, resource exploitation and increased climate change effects through industrialization etc. Global capitalism plays a significant role in global politics and global governance by promoting regional integration, cooperation and peace through trade and commerce. It also promotes foreign direct investment through multinational corporations and financial institutions like the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and the World Bank. For example, despite the financial risk and criticism, China's Belt and Road project (Bridges and Roads project) initiative in Africa is going a long way in advancing infrastructural development in the African continent.

In conclusion, Marxist view of global capitalism focuses on the economic and structural crisis of capitalism which put emphasis on historical materialism, looking into the historically evolving

structures and practices which have crossed national boundaries and linked the domestic and the international, the economic and the political, (Griffiths, 2007). This explains that politics and economics are two inseparable aspects of life that influences and compliments one another. Marxist also, in explaining global capitalism discusses the economic exploitation rooted in the system and the class difference between the poor and the rich, the bourgeois and the proletariat.

Critical theorist identified gaps in the Marxist theory delving into the cultural dimensions of inequality that the system has created in the world. This made Griffiths to conclude that integration of both the Marxist theory (material and economic dimension) and the critical theory (Cultural dimension) is necessary in better understanding the influence and impact of global capitalism on states and individuals.

Section 3: Simulation Exercise (20%)

Scenario: Analyze a territorial dispute using one IR theory; describe motivations, actions, and outcomes. Include relevant quotes from assigned readings to support your analysis.

TOPIC: Analyzing Russia's annexation of Crimea using the realist theory of international relations

The Crimean peninsula located on the Black Sea, is a strategically located area for both Ukraine and Russia. Historically, Crimea was home to three indigenous people: Karaites, Krymchaks, and Crimean Tatars. In February 2014, Russia annexed and reclaimed the site on the bases that Crimea had been a part of its territory in the 18th century. Additionally, there have been claims that Crimea is culturally and historically very important to Russia. The Crimean peninsula on the Black Sea is strategically located to provide easy access to the Balkans, Middle East and the Mediterranean Sea.

Aside from the cultural and historical significance Russia claimed the place holds, Moscow's real intentions for reclaiming Crimea are politically motivated. Russia as argued by international relations analyst, wanted to influence the governance model of Ukraine to a system of confederation in order to give autonomy to the Russian population in Ukraine with the sole aim of maintaining dominance in a country globally recognized as a sovereign independent state who has right to self-determinations. Russia's move was described as a "self-defense" move, however in one of his statements Vladimir Putin clarified that Crimea was seized with well-equipped military personnel not by any paramilitary "self-defense" force.

Critics following the Russia Ukraine events, argue that Vladimir Putin's reaction is also in response to Ukraine's attempt to form alliances with the Western block and NATO for security measures. Others argue that Russia's annexation of Crimea was in connection to its strategic location on the Black Sea critical for the naval and military operations of Russia. Ukraine's attempt to join NATO exposes Russia to external security threats mainly from its US rivalry which prompted Russian president Putin to act rationally in the country's national interest and defense.

This clearly explain the position of realist like Kenneth Waltz who is his arguments posit that "In an anarchy order, the possibility that force will be used by one or another requires states to be on guard" (Waltz, 1979). According to realist, states are the primary, unitary and rational actors whose decisions are shaped by their interest determined by their military and economic capability in a global system where there is no central authority. Realist theorize that power, self-interest, fear, and honor are the driving forces of state behavior in anarchy. Realists see states as single coherent actors in pursuing the national interest. They prioritize national security and self-interest. Scholars like E.H Carr, Machiavelli, Hans Morgenthau, Thucydides , Thomas Hobbes and others see

conflict or war as a result of rational decisions by states necessitated by the nature of the international system. It rejects morality and doesn't believe in change. It's based on the principle of self-help where states increase their power to be able to be at the center of international affairs as evident in Vladimir Putin's annexation of the Crimean peninsula in Ukraine.

Russia's annexation of Crimea in the realist perspective was to deter western dominance within its sphere of influence and to control NATO's expansion. Although this move later came at a cost thus Russia faced economic sanctions imposed to weaken its economy. Notwithstanding, realist view sanctions like this as necessary tradeoffs for national interest. The Russia Ukraine territorial conflict over Crimea is better explained in the realist lens not because of its state centric views but because of the theory's consistency and accuracy in explaining the intricate international system. To date, realism remained one of the most important theories in the field of international relations that offers a broad explanation of the nature of the state and its interaction with others in the global system.

Section 4: Synthesis and Reflection (10%)

Question: "How do Waltz's structural realism and Reus-Smit's Constructivism differ on anarchy? Provide specific references from the readings to support your answer."

Walt's theory on structural realism or neorealism states that power is the most significant factor in international relations. He divides the theory into two parts, defensive and offensive realism. Offensive realism yearns for influence and power to achieve security through dominance and hegemony whilst defensive realism, unlike the offensive realism, defensive realism frowns at the idea of power dominance as it affects the tendency of states conforming to the balance of power theory, reducing their primary objective as a state. Simply, in defensive realism, the anarchic structure of international systems promotes states to reserve policies to attain security. This does

not mean defensive realism rejects the existence of interstate conflict or that the motivation for state to grow does not exist, it actually argues that these incentives are occasional rather than restricted.

Waltz focused on describing the anarchy structure of the international system and how that influences power dynamics, arguing that striking qualitative differences exist between policies conducted in a condition of settled rules and politics conducted in a condition of anarchy, (Waltz, 1979). The central theoretical conclusion of Waltz's structural realism is that in anarchy states "balance" rather than "bandwagon". In hierarchic political orders, weaker states tend to align with stronger powers to increase gains or avoid losses. Waltz further introduces additional motives that undermine the logical coherence of his theory which attracted criticism from scholars. In Burchill et. al., Synder criticized his structural realism, arguing that while it offers powerful explanation based on the system's structure, it is overly simplistic. Synder is of the view that norms and institutions like structural forces can influence states behavior and global politics in the international system, (Burchill et. al., 2005).

On the other hand, Reus- Smith's theory on constructivism reshapes anarchy, the balance of power and the relationships between state interests and identity. His theory is based on Sophist and Socrates' idea of acquiring knowledge and understanding reality, this led to his theory looking into social constructivism in three folds or types. Symbolic interaction which is less social in nature but has a radical approach. The second type is social constructivism which focuses on discourse communities with their own common language and knowledge such as mathematicians and physicians. Lastly, socio- cultural constructivism consists of the US belief that knowledge is socially constructed and that it's defined by people's social interaction and other belief argues that

behavior has past history, mental functions depend on social interactions and that the key to understanding one another requires mediator tools and signs according to Vigostsky.

Smit argues that the theory of international politics is highly influenced by American or US belief. To him constructivism in international politics seeks to attain an understanding between reflectivity and rational approaches which he popularly calls it the middle ground position. Rationalist hold that agents are separate from the environment they live in and that international politics encompasses the study of agents instrumental pursuit of pre social interest that remain constant over the course of social interaction. For Reus-Smit, the international system is constitutive rather than merely a strategic domain, (Reus-Smit, 1999). Basically for Smit, rather than a theory, constructivism is a means of understanding international politics and the grounds that states international relations are constructed.

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